

Backcountry Ski Playbook

Operating Philosophy

- The objective is never the summit, the line, or the descent. The objective is making a series of good decisions throughout the day. A successful trip is one where decisions remain rational even when conditions, expectations, or emotions begin pulling in different directions. Mountains will always be there next weekend. Good judgment is harder to replace.

Planning vs Commitment

- A route is a working hypothesis, not a contract. Research, forecasts, maps, and previous reports provide a starting point, but they do not remove uncertainty. The purpose of planning is to improve flexibility, not eliminate it. If reality disagrees with the plan, reality wins.

Decision Points

- Stop regularly and ask what has changed since the trip began. Conditions evolve. Energy levels change. Weather shifts. Reassessing throughout the day prevents small concerns from becoming major problems. A good decision made late is still a good decision.

Managing Risk

- Most poor decisions begin with urgency. Feeling behind schedule, wanting to justify preparation effort, or chasing an objective after investing time often creates unnecessary pressure. Slow down, reassess, and remember that turning around is a skill, not a failure.

Post■Trip Review

- Record observations, lessons learned, equipment issues, and moments where judgment mattered. Experience grows faster when trips are reviewed honestly rather than simply completed.